

The Kingdom Is Not a Party Platform

Jesus refused the Zealots and the Herodians both. Every generation since has tried to draft him anyway, and ours is no exception.

THE TRIAL

A Kingdom Not From Here

The most political conversation in the Gospels happens between a provincial governor and a prisoner already condemned in the minds of everyone watching. Pilate asks Jesus whether he is a king. Jesus answers: my kingdom is not of this world. If it were, my servants would fight.

Generations of readers have taken that sentence as a resignation letter from public life, as though Jesus were saying his kingdom is private, inward, safely spiritual. N.T. Wright has spent a career correcting the mistake. The Greek says the kingdom is not from this world. Its origin is elsewhere. Its arena is right here. Jesus is not telling Pilate that his kingship is irrelevant to Caesar. He is telling Pilate where his kingship comes from, which is precisely why Rome should worry, and why Pilate, who understood power better than we do, had the charge nailed above his head in three languages.

A kingdom not from the world cannot be captured by the world's machinery. It does not arrive by sword, ballot, or coalition. That is not its weakness. That is the entire point, and it is the point every politically captive church has had to forget first.

THE REFUSALS

Neither Zealot nor Herodian

First-century Judea offered Jesus two ready-made political identities, and he refused them both.

The Zealot option: holy violence against Rome, the kingdom by insurrection. Jesus had a Zealot among the Twelve, preached love of enemies to crowds who wanted Rome's blood, rode into Jerusalem on a donkey instead of a warhorse, and told Peter to put the sword away on the one night a sword made tactical sense. The revolution was real. The weapon was a cross.

The Herodian option: accommodation, blessing the existing arrangement, religion as the decoration of power. Herod's court was full of such chaplains. Jesus called Herod a fox and kept walking toward

Jerusalem on his own schedule.

When Pharisees and Herodians together tried to trap him over the census tax, he asked whose image was on the coin and then split the world in two: give Caesar the coin that bears his image, give God what bears God's image, which is to say yourselves, which is to say everything. The coin is small. The claim is total.

Every modern church is still being offered the same two careers, militant or chaplain. The donkey was a third thing. It still is.

THE HISTORY

Conscripting Christ

Every generation drafts Jesus into its army, and the paperwork goes back to a battlefield. In 312, Constantine saw a sign above the Milvian Bridge and conquered under it, and within a century the empire that crucified Christ was enforcing his worship by law. Oliver O'Donovan reads that history more charitably than most, and even he insists that the church's obedience can never be fused with the state's sword without loss.

The drafts since then have been relentless. Crusaders wore the cross as a unit insignia. Both Civil War armies sang Christ as their captain, and Mark Noll has shown how that collision broke the country's confidence that Scripture could settle anything. In 1933, the German Christians draped the swastika beside the altar while Bonhoeffer and the confessing remnant paid the price of refusing.

And lest the indictment land on one side only: Jesus has been conscripted as a free-market apologist and as a socialist organizer, as the guarantor of national greatness and as the mascot of every progressive cause that needed a halo. The uniforms change. The conscription is identical. I have written him recruitment letters of my own, in sermons I preached with full conviction and would now like back.

THE CREED

An Allegiance Above Every Allegiance

The earliest Christian creed was three words: Jesus is Lord. In the first century that sentence carried a political edge we have dulled, because Caesar already held the titles, lord, savior, son of god, bringer of peace. To confess Jesus as Lord was not to add a religious opinion to your civic life. It was to announce which throne held final claim on you, and Christians died over the difference.

Final allegiance relativizes every lesser one. It does not abolish them. Paul carried Roman citizenship and used it when it served the gospel. Christians may vote, organize, serve, run for office, govern. What we may not do is hand any party the loyalty that belongs to the Lord alone, because the moment a platform owns your conscience, it will eventually instruct your exegesis, and you will obey it without noticing you

have changed masters.

James Davison Hunter calls the alternative faithful presence, and the phrase is right precisely because it promises so little. Presence, not possession. Witness, not management. The church does not need to hold power to tell the truth about power. It needs only to remember whose it is.

THE EXAMINATION

Name What Your Party Gets Wrong

Here is a test for whether the kingdom or the platform is doing your thinking. Can you name a position your own party holds that your King condemns? Name it out loud, in front of your own side, where it costs you something. If you cannot think of one, your discipleship has been outsourced. If you can think of one but have never said it where it counts, then mine has been too, more often than I want to write down.

The kingdom is not the Republican platform with communion added. It is not the Democratic platform with liturgy added. It is not a centrist compromise between them, as though Jesus were waiting patiently at the midpoint of American opinion. It is a throne. Thrones do not negotiate for our votes. They ask whether we will bow.

Every four years this country tells the church that this election, finally, is the one that justifies full capture. Every four years some of us believe it. The kingdom we actually serve was not on the last ballot and will not be on the next one. It is the only one still standing when the counting ends, and it remembers how its servants behaved while the polls were open.

KEY TEXTS

John 18:33-37

Mark 12:13-17

Philippians 2:9-11

SOURCES

How God Became King: The Forgotten Story of the Gospels — N.T. Wright

The Desire of the Nations: Rediscovering the Roots of Political Theology — Oliver O'Donovan

To Change the World: The Irony, Tragedy, and Possibility of Christianity in the Late Modern World — James Davison Hunter

The Politics of Jesus — John Howard Yoder